a tactic in pursuit of communist control over a broad range of centrist political forces, as the Comintern realised that Communists in Western Europe could not carry out a revolution by themselves. In the new circumstances of Nazi attack, these coalitions were meant to gain broad public support for armed resistance movements as well as for the Communist parties to assume the pivotal and exclusive role in these Fronts – at gunpoint, if necessary.

This Soviet strategy was not always successful and local left and centrist political forces occasionally acted against the expectations of Moscow. In Poland, there was a strong resistance movement that was not associated with the Communists. It was much the same in Czechoslovakia, where the resistance focused on intelligence gathering, sabotage and Czechoslovak soldiers joining Allies abroad. In Slovenia, Communists assumed the leading role in the resistance and did so by physically eliminating not only those who decided to wait, but also many of those who were ready to fight against the Nazis and the Fascists but did not want to be associated with a Communist revolution. This created impossible, absurd situations in which the anti-Communist side even asked the occupying forces for arms in order to protect themselves from Communist terror; in turn then the Communists accused the anti-Communists of treason. Even today, this is still a source of controversy and divisions among historians and ordinary people in Slovenia and elsewhere.

Once the British and Americans realised that the most imminent threat to the liberal order was coming from Nazism and that, consequently, the Soviet Union would have to be brought into the war to beat Hitler, they became ready to deal with the Soviet Union, including to trade Soviet influence over Eastern Europe for Soviet military involvement. As early as 1943, in Tehran, Churchill and Roosevelt consented to Stalin’s territorial request for the Baltic States, eastern Poland and Bessarabia (the eastern part of Moldavia). It appears that even Roosevelt downplayed the sinister nature of Moscow’s demand for a zone of influence over Eastern Europe, and considered such a demand legitimate. Part of the Soviet argument, as described above, was that some of the Eastern European countries were hostile to the Soviet Union and were desperate enough to be ready to allow the transportation of German troops across their territories. But the Soviets acted just the same in Czechoslovakia which was friendly to Russia.